INTERVIEW GUIDE · STAR DEEP DIVE

Senior SRE

Platform team · 60 min

CANDIDATE | INTERVIEWER | DATE

THE CASE

Our online store makes most of its revenue through checkout. Last month checkout went down for 25 minutes during a campaign, and Black Friday is in six weeks with up to 3 times normal traffic. Leadership wants to know whether we're ready, what it will cost to be ready, and how we'll know in real time if something breaks.

What this role protects: Availability customers feel · Revenue protected on peak days · Cloud cost

HOW TO EVALUATE

S Situation — a real case, with its business stake	**T** Task — what was theirs to solve, and the goal	**A** Action — what they did and why, options discarded	**R** Result — what changed, in numbers, for the business

Score: 4 strong (full STAR + business impact) · 3 good · 2 partial · 1 weak

1 · UNDERSTAND THE BUSINESS

1 Tell me about a system you kept running that made money directly. How did you find out what an hour of downtime cost the business?

Dig deeper: Who gave you that number, and how did it change your priorities?
Strong answer: *Knows revenue per minute or a proxy, got it from finance or product, and used it to prioritize.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

2 Before touching anything for Black Friday, what would you ask product and finance about our checkout?

Dig deeper: Which of those answers would change your plan the most?
Strong answer: *Asks peak traffic, revenue per hour, campaigns and acceptable degradation: why before how.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

3 Tell me about an SLO you defined with a business owner. How did you choose the target?

Dig deeper: What happened the first time you burned the error budget?
Strong answer: *Target tied to customer experience and the cost of each extra nine; business owner involved.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

4 In our case, which parts of checkout can degrade on Black Friday and which can never fail? How do you decide?

Dig deeper: Who signs off on that list?
Strong answer: *Separates the payment path from nice-to-haves, decides with product, plans graceful degradation.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

2 · DESIGN AND TRADE-OFFS

5 Leadership gives you budget for one thing before Black Friday: more capacity, a load test or better alerts. Which one and why?

Dig deeper: What do we lose with the options you didn't choose?
Strong answer: *Compares cost against revenue at risk per hour; picks with data; names what stays uncovered.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

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6 **Tell me about a time you chose between scaling up and fixing the root cause under time pressure. What did each option cost?**

Dig deeper: Looking back, was it the right call? What would you change?

Strong answer: *Weighs cost, time and risk explicitly, decides consciously and follows up on the debt.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

7 **Our database is the bottleneck at 2 times traffic. How would you reach 3 times in six weeks, and how would you explain the cost to leadership?**

Dig deeper: What's the cheapest option that still protects revenue?

Strong answer: *Options with cost and risk (replicas, cache, queues, limits), picks with data, one-line business case.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

8 **Tell me about a cloud cost you reduced without hurting customers. How did you prove it didn't?**

Dig deeper: What was the saving per month and what did you watch after the change?

Strong answer: *Saving in money, before/after metrics, guardrails and evidence that customers weren't affected.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

3 · EXECUTION AND INCIDENTS

9 **Tell me about the worst incident you handled. What did it cost the business, and what did you do in the first 15 minutes?**

Dig deeper: What did you tell leadership and customers, and when?

Strong answer: *Real case, own actions, stops the bleeding first, communicates early, impact quantified.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

10 **It's Black Friday, 9 pm, and checkout errors are at 8%. Walk me through your next 30 minutes.**

Dig deeper: When do you roll back without knowing the cause?

Strong answer: *Mitigates before diagnosing, clear rollback criteria, roles and comms cadence; protects revenue.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

11 **Tell me about a postmortem that changed how the company works, not only the code.**

Dig deeper: How did you make sure the action items actually happened?

Strong answer: *Blameless, business impact stated, a systemic change, owners and dates followed up.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

12 **How would you load-test checkout at 3 times traffic without risking real customers or real payments?**

Dig deeper: What result would make you tell leadership we're not ready?

Strong answer: *Production-like test, payment sandbox, ramp plan and a go/no-go threshold tied to the business.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

4 · IMPACT AND METRICS

13 **Tell me about reliability work whose value you had to prove. What number did you show, and to whom?**

Dig deeper: How did you turn minutes saved into money or customers?

Strong answer: *Climbs from output to outcome to impact: incidents and MTTR into downtime avoided and revenue.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

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14 **After Black Friday, which three numbers would you report to show the preparation was worth it?**

Dig deeper: Which of them would the CFO care about most?

Strong answer: *Availability at peak, failed orders or revenue protected, cost of preparing; compared with last year.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

15 **Tell me about toil you automated. How many hours did it free, and what did the team do with them?**

Dig deeper: How did you measure those hours?

Strong answer: *Hours measured before and after and reinvested in valuable work, not just 'I automated X'.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

16 **How would you know in real time that Black Friday is going well for the business, not only for the servers?**

Dig deeper: Which alert would wake you up?

Strong answer: *Business metrics on screen (orders per minute, payment success); alerts on customer impact, not CPU.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

5 · STAKEHOLDERS AND COMMUNICATION

17 **Tell me about a time you asked for budget or people for reliability. How did you make the case?**

Dig deeper: What did you say the business would lose without it?

Strong answer: *Risk of not doing it in money or customers, a clear ask, alternatives and the real outcome.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

18 **Leadership asks 'Are we ready for Black Friday?' and you're not sure. What do you answer?**

Dig deeper: How do you say 'not yet' without sounding like a blocker?

Strong answer: *Honest status with risks, what's needed and by when, options; no false confidence.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

19 **Tell me about a time you said no to a launch or a change for reliability reasons. How did it end?**

Dig deeper: What did you offer instead?

Strong answer: *Explains the risk in business terms, offers conditions or an alternative, keeps the relationship.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

20 **How would you explain a 25-minute checkout outage to the sales team in two sentences?**

Dig deeper: What would you never say to them?

Strong answer: *Plain words: what happened, the impact, what changed. No jargon, no blame, no excuses.*

Heard ☐ S ☐ T ☐ A ☐ R Score ◯ 1 ◯ 2 ◯ 3 ◯ 4

CANDIDATE'S ANSWER

FINAL ASSESSMENT

STRENGTHS

CONCERNS

AVERAGE SCORE (1-4)

RECOMMENDATION

◯ Strong yes ◯ Yes ◯ No ◯ Strong no

NEXT STEP

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